

Mussorgsky's musical ambitions revived after he joined a group of avant-garde composers now known as the Mighty Handful or The Five. Led by Mily Balakirev (see [box](#)), this included Alexander Borodin, César Cui, and Nikolai Rimsky-Korsakov. Mussorgsky persuaded Balakirev to give him lessons in composition. These were somewhat basic but fired the young man's enthusiasm. He abandoned his army career and began work on a number of projects.



THE MIGHTY HANDFUL, 1871

This reproduction shows the group of avant-garde composers, the Mighty Handful (or The Five), who reignited Mussorgsky's interest in music.

A perfect storm

Progress was disappointingly slow. In 1858, Mussorgsky suffered some form of mental breakdown (which his family described as nerves). He recovered gradually, but was affected increasingly by